The Decline in Black Male College Enrollment: Data Analysis

Chenaniah S. Watkins

Vanderbilt University

PPS 3200: Research Methods for Public Policy Analysis

Dr. Gilbert Gonzales

December 4, 2025

Literature Review

In recent years, there has been a decline in Black male college enrollment. Across all institutions in the U.S., the amount of Black male students attending them fell 22% between 2010 and 2022 (LaSane, 2025). However, this is the opposite case for Black women. The enrollment among Black females is on the rise. It is important that we address this gap in enrollment between Black females and Black males. Fewer Black men attending college leads to lower degree attainment which means reduced wages. Reduced wages create fewer opportunities for social and economic mobility (LaSane, 2025). This also reduces representation in professional and leadership fields. By understanding why fewer Black men are attending college it will help reveal how systemic racism, economic barriers, and institutional inequality shape access to higher education for Black men.

One factor that greatly affects Black men wanting to attend college is systemic racism. Black men greatly experience racism when entering any kind of educational space. Having to deal with racially motivated bias, and constant microaggressions gives the feeling that they are unwanted there, so they stop trying to make themselves a part of these types of spaces (Brooms et al., 2024). Feeling unwelcome deter Black men from seeking out educational attainment of any kind, especially college. This is not the same case for Black women. Some empirical studies show that Black women show a stronger commitment to academics which may be because of having higher self-efficacy levels and more effective coping strategies when faced with discrimination compared to Black men (Hamann et al., 2021).

Another factor that deters Black men from seeking higher education are economic barriers. Financial strain can be a big deterrent for Black men when deciding to go to college. They decide to prioritize financial responsibilities over long-term educational goals because they

are at risk of being weighed down by college tuition, and other related costs or burdens that attending college can bring (Zhou & Pan, 2023). These financial responsibilities can include being a provider for the family since men are usually considered providers. However, evidence suggests that Black women often bear the role of the primary breadwinner in families, which influences them to seek higher education in hopes of getting better employment opportunities (Conwell & Quadlin, 2021). Also Black men may seek out lower wage jobs instead of ones that need a higher education because they face intense discrimination in those positions. On the other hand Black women seek out higher paying jobs that need a degree due to societal expectations around success and stability.

Institutional inequality plays a big role in influencing Black men on whether or not they should attend college. Unequal K–12 preparation, and insufficient college readiness resources reduce Black men's chances of enrollment and degree completion. Due to the unequal preparation it creates an educational gap between Black men and their female counterparts in college enrollment rates (Witteveen & Attewell, 2022). Support during college is equally as important to support before college. Institutions that have active supportive environments like mentorship programs and community-building efforts can significantly increase persistence, so that when Black men get to college they graduate (McNeill et al., 2023).

The decline in Black male college enrollment is a multidimensional problem. There is not just one factor that is making it decline. Despite there being so much research on Black male college enrollment not much of it focuses on the quantitative side, or data from after 2020. I hope to further prove the causes of Black male college enrollment by using data, and comparing Black male enrollment to Black female enrollment to further see the differences between the two groups.

Data & Methods

The data used for this research was collected from the 2023 ACS (American Community Survey), which is a household survey that gathers data throughout the year on U.S. populations (Bureau of Labor Statistics, 2023). Specifically, it collects from about 3.5 million addresses a year. The survey is conducted by internet, mail, telephone, and in-person interviews. It was developed by the U.S. Census Bureau to replace the decennial census program. It looks at economic, social, housing, and demographic characteristics. Estimates are produced for all characteristics.

This study analyzed the college enrollment status of Black men ages 18-25. First, I made a new variable, so that the data set only looked at Black men ages 18-25. This allowed me to tabulate my independent variable against my dependent variables to analyze what was causing the decrease in their college enrollment, which gave the overall overview of the data (descriptive statistics). The sample size of this study was 32,901. The study looked at numerous dependent variables compared to enrollment, which is the independent variable. The dependent variables included educational attainment (level of education they attained so far), household income, employment status, region, and metropolitan v.s. non-metropolitan areas. The enrollment variable was a binary variable. Yes if you are enrolled in college, and no if you are not enrolled in college. Metro and non-metro areas was also a binary variable. Yes or no if you lived in a metro and vice versa for non-metro. All the other variables are set/coded into categories, and based on what the respondents said according to the ACS they are put into those categories. For educational attainment it is separated into high school graduate, some college, and college graduate. Employment status is also coded into three categories including unemployed, part time, and full time. Region and household income are in four categories. Region is Northeast,

Midwest, South, and West. Lastly, household income is under 25,000, (25,000-49,999), (50,000-99,999), and 100,000 & up.

I used descriptive statistics with cross tabulations (sense of general trends), and logistic regression analysis to examine why Black male college enrollment is declining. I was able to compare Black male college enrollment to Black female college enrollment in the same age group. I used logistic regression analysis to make comparisons between the different dependent variables based on Black male college enrollment versus Black female college enrollment. Odds ratios are present in my analysis. The regression has the same variables as the descriptive except it is comparing it to another group of respondents (Black women in the same age group). All analyses were conducted in Stata using survey weights to ensure accurate data.

Results

Table 1 looks at the difference between Black men enrolled in college and not enrolled in college based on household income, educational attainment, region, metropolitan area, and employment status. Some of these categories do not have that much effect on Black male college enrollment compared to the others. Overall, Black men who are in college have much higher rates of graduating high school, which is 45.9 percent compared to the 21.9 percent of those who are not enrolled in college and graduated high school. Only 38.7 percent have graduated with a college degree, but since I am focusing on the age range 18-25 many of them could still be in college and just not have graduated yet. For household income Black men are more likely to be enrolled in college if their household makes more than 100,000 dollars. They are also somewhat likely to be enrolled in college if their household is in the 50,000-99,999 dollars range, but definitely not as much as 100,000 dollars and up category. The categories under 50,000 dollars have minimum college enrollment. Enrollment rates across regions and metropolitan areas are

fairly the same. 53 percent of Black men who are not enrolled in college have a full-time job. If they are enrolled in college they are more likely to have a part-time job (14.8%), or not be employed at all (74.3%).

The second set of descriptive statistics, which is table 2 shows the differences amongst college enrollment between Black men and women ages 18-25 using the same dependent variables as Table 1. Not being enrolled in college is much higher for Black men than Black women (63.1% vs 55.0%). 45 percent of Black women are enrolled in college compared to the Black men 36.9 percent. The women have higher rates of graduating high school and graduating college in comparison to men (31.8% vs 27.3%). There are more men in the higher income brackets compared to women (42.6% vs 37.6%). The women are more likely to fall in the 25,000-49,999 and under 25,000 categories than the men. Both Black men and women are largely located in the south and non-metropolitan areas. Black men have higher full-time employment compared to Black women (41.2% vs 39%). Black women have higher part-time employment compared to Black men (35.3% vs 28.9%).

A logistic regression analysis was used for table 3. It looks at the odds ratios of college enrollment among Black men and women that are the ages 18-25. Based off of table 3 Black men have 45 percent lower odds of being enrolled in college than Black women (OR = 0.55). Also the regression table shows that there is a statistically significant difference in odds of being enrolled in college amongst the different income brackets. There are higher odds for college enrollment for the 50,000-99,999 dollars bracket (OR = 1.295). For household incomes higher than 100 thousand it is three times higher odds that they will be enrolled in college compared to those under 25 thousand (OR = 2.99). There is no strong difference in enrollment odds for region or metropolitan area. Employment is strongly related to enrollment status. Those who are working

full-time have 66 percent lower odds of being enrolled in college (OR = 0.34). While part-time workers have higher odds of being enrolled in college (OR = 1.61).

Discussion

The study used nationally representative data to look at the differences in college enrollment amongst Black men in the age range 18-25 compared to Black women in the same age group. In comparison to Black women, Black men have significantly lower odds of being enrolled in college (OR = 0.55). This result supports that there are gender disparities in Black college enrollment. Black women are attending college more than Black men, and there are numerous factors behind this. Many of them involve structural or social barriers that are uniquely affecting Black men.

The main factor that was shown in this study was the economic barriers which were highlighted with employment and household income. Higher household income greatly increased enrollment odds amongst Black men and women (OR = 2.99 for 100k+). This supports the previous studies that showed Black men from lower income households struggle paying for college, which prevents enrollment and continuity once in college. In addition, employment status played a major part in determining enrollment. Those who are working full-time have 66 percent lower odds of being enrolled in college, while those who are working part-time or unemployed are more likely to be enrolled in college. These findings suggest that Black men are pulled into full-time work earlier due to financial responsibilities.

In terms of policy recommendations, it is important to increase Black male college enrollment to not only fill the gap between Black men and women, but also to continue to support Black college enrollment overall. Increasing Black college enrollment, and especially Black male college enrollment will increase representation in professional fields, and help

economic growth. To address the college enrollment gap between Black men and women there should be programs directly targeting Black male high school students. In these programs they should be mentored in helping find a college that fits them, and showing them why it is important to go to college. By having this type of support they will see that they are wanted in higher education settings. One of the reasons Black men do not seek out higher education is because they do not feel like they belong, so they instead go directly to the work force. The emotional support through mentorship and counseling will give them the push they need to enroll in college. Also by having these types of programs early in their academic career like beginning of high school or end of middle school it will show them college is an option early on.

I would recommend to policymakers to help reduce financial barriers. With the current presidential administration they are proposing budget cuts that could significantly impact federal student aid. By taking away aid the financial burden will increase, which will continue to deter Black men from enrolling in college. Instead they should find ways to increase tuition assistance, and specifically strengthen need based aid for low income families. Easing the financial burden will make more people attend college, not just Black men, but anyone who wants to further their education. In the targeted program for Black men I mentioned earlier they should also help with finding scholarships that they could apply to. Likewise, there should be an increase in scholarship and grant programs directly targeting Black men who are first generation or low income. Having scholarships and grants targeted towards them will not only show them that they belong in academic spaces, but also take away financial stress.

There should also be more programs that allow people to work while also attending school. Providing more accommodating degree programs that offer flexible scheduling, online classes, and even part-time pathways allow people to get a degree and make money at the same

time. This will increase Black male college enrollment because they will no longer have to deal with the work or school tradeoff. Instead they will be able to obtain a higher education without having to feel extreme economic pressure. Also, incentivizing more companies to offer tuition assistance and more flexible hours can be helpful. It can allow more Black men to work while also in college, so they can be working towards a degree, and have some sort of economic stability.

If we do not address the gap between Black male college enrollment and Black female college enrollment it will continue to widen. This is important because Black men will have less access to higher paying jobs which decreases diversity in leadership roles and professional fields. This will also continue the cycles of poverty that Black men from low income households may already face. By assessing this problem it will also address institutional inequality. Specifically the unequal K–12 preparation, and insufficient college readiness resources Black and low income areas receive. In light of my results further research should be done on more qualitative barriers. Looking at things like school climate and counseling access for both before enrollment and after can show whether Black men are getting enough support in any part of their life regarding higher education. Also looking at state policies already in place like workforce development initiatives can help further pinpoint why Black male college enrollment is declining. Future research should look at the types of job Black men are choosing to do instead of enrolling in college as well. In this current era we live in, entrepreneurship is extremely pushed through social media, so it would be interesting to see if that is affecting their college enrollment rate.

Limitations

There were several limitations in my study that prevented me from finding all the possible reasons why Black male college enrollment is declining. First there were limitations

regarding my data set. For my data I only looked at one year, so I am not able to see the decline in Black male college enrollment. With the data used I can really only compare Black men ages 18-25 to Black women ages 18-25 during 2023. Having multiple years would allow me to see the trend of declinement. Also the ACS is a self reported survey, so the reporting may not be accurate regarding household income or employment status. Another factor affecting my results is the educational attainment variable. That variable could be potentially considering people who are still in college in the high school graduate category.

In addition the variables that I could look at using the ACS were limited. I was unable to measure factors like access to counseling, high school quality, and just overall college readiness. Seeing if they were ready for college could have allowed me to see the differences in high school preparation. Also looking at variables like parental education could have shown if Black men are more likely to go to college if their parents went to college. Another weakness in my study is that I was unable to look at social or psychological factors. Discrimination plays a major part in Black male college enrollment, and the ACS survey cannot analyze whether or not they are experiencing it in academic settings. Feeling unwanted in a classroom also affects motivation which is another variable in my study. A possible constraint in my study is not being able to see who dropped out of college. By seeing who dropped out it would allow me to see if they attempted college, and show whether staying in college is a bigger problem than deciding to go to college. Also I was unable to look at a variable on student loan access or financial aid, which could help show if money was a problem.

Previous literature on Black male college enrollment showed that economic, personal, and structural factors are intertwined in determining whether Black men will attend college. The ACS can not fully show the effect of these factors on Black male college enrollment. First

example looking at who is enrolled in college, and who is not does clearly tell a story. Each individual could have similar or different reasons or factors preventing them from attending. Since there are so many I am not able to identify the exact cause of the current decrease in Black male college enrollment, but get an overall jist. I also am not able to see what happens to them while attending college, which is also a big factor in actually graduating. Also I did not look at if they decide to attend college later in life instead of the age range I focused on.

Conclusion

This study focused on Black male college enrollment focusing those who are 18 to 25 years old using the ACS survey. It looked at numerous variables: educational attainment, household income, region, non-metro versus metro area, employment status. These variables were analyzed by looking at enrollment status which was a binary variable (yes or no). The results were analyzed through a descriptive and logistic statistical lens. Black men coming from low income households were less likely to attend college. Black men who were working full time were less likely to be enrolled in college as well. Based on the results found it is evident that there are factors deterring Black men from attending college. Specifically for my study it highlighted that economic pressures and labor force participation heavily determine whether Black men will be enrolled in college.

To answer why there is a decline in Black male enrollment we must assume that all of these factors play a part. To truly see what is exactly affecting each individual, or the overall group, we would have to look at things on a micro level. Unfortunately this study did not look at enough variables that followed Black men once they were in college, or other variables that could be affecting them while in K-12. This study did further support that Black women are more likely to be enrolled in college than Black men. The gap between Black male college enrollment

and Black female college enrollment must be addressed. Not addressing it will affect economic mobility, and decrease the amount of Black men in professional fields and leadership roles that require higher education.

Helping bridge the gap between Black male and female college enrollment is more than just one policy. There needs to be numerous initiatives to combat the decline in Black male college enrollment. Moving forward there need to be more policies or programs that directly help young Black males see that college is an option. These programs can help them craft a plan to attend college, and help them find ways to fund it. The financial part is a huge burden, so policies helping with financial aid for need-based individuals will increase enrollment. Many Black males have to jump straight into the workforce to stay a float, so providing more state funded tuition programs or grants will allow more Black males to enroll in college instead of being deterred by the financial aspect. There are remaining research gaps regarding Black male college enrollment that need to be addressed. There needs to be more research on drop out rates for college specifically focusing on Black men. By looking at this we can see whether or not the college atmosphere is negatively affecting Black men. Also someone should look at the jobs most Black men are choosing to seek employment in. This will show whether they are choosing an entrepreneurial route which is extremely popular right now in the world. Overall, we need a more microscopic focus to analyze why Black male college enrollment is declining.

Table 1: Descriptive statistics of Black men ages 18-25 by enrollment status

Categories	Not Enrolled	Enrolled
Educational Attainment		
HS Graduate	21.9%	45.9%
Some College / Associate	15.2%	15.3%
College Graduate	62.9%	38.7%
Household Income		
Under $25,000	10.3%	10.2%
$25,000–49,999	14.2%	13.1%
$50,000–99,999	28.3%	25.9%
$100,000+	47.2%	50.8%
Region		
Northeast	17.2%	16.5%
Midwest	20.6%	20.4%
South	38.7%	39.1%
West	23.4%	24.1%
Metropolitan Area		
Non-metropolitan	75.9%	77.5%
Metropolitan	24.1%	22.5%
Employment Status		
Not employed	34.7%	74.3%
Part-time	12.3%	14.8%
Full-time	53.0%	10.9%

Table 2: Descriptive statistics of Black men and women ages 18-25 by enrollment status

Categories	Black Women	Black Men
Enrollment Status		
Not enrolled	55.0%	63.1%
Enrolled	45.0%	36.9%
Educational Attainment		
HS Graduate	55.8%	59.2%
Some College / Associate	12.3%	13.5%
College Graduate	31.8%	27.3%
Household Income		
Under $25,000	17.0%	12.3%
$25,000–49,999	18.3%	16.8%

$50,000–99,999	27.0%	28.3%
$100,000+	37.6%	42.6%
Region		
Northeast	15.9%	15.3%
Midwest	17.1%	16.9%
South	59.0%	58.7%
West	8.0%	9.1%
Metropolitan Area		
Non-metropolitan	89.3%	87.3%
Metropolitan	10.7%	12.7%
Employment Status		
Not employed	25.7%	29.9%
Part-time	35.3%	28.9%
Full-time	39.0%	41.2%

Table 3: A logistic regression displaying odds ratios of college enrollment among Black men and women ages 18-25

	Odds Ratio (OR)	**95% CI**	**p-value**
Black young male	0.55	0.51 – 0.60	<0.01
Household Income			
$25,000–49,999	1.01	0.87 – 1.18	0.85
$50,000–99,999	1.30	1.13 – 1.49	<0.01
$100,000+	2.99	2.65 – 3.38	<0.01
Employment Status			
Part-time	1.61	1.47 – 1.76	<0.01
Full-time	0.34	0.30 – 0.37	<0.01
Region			
Midwest	0.95	0.84 – 1.09	0.48
South	1.04	0.95 – 1.15	0.41
West	0.93	0.79 – 1.10	0.41
Metropolitan area	1.00	0.90 – 1.11	0.99
Constant	0.78	0.68 – 0.90	<0.01

References

American community survey (Acs) questions and answers. (n.d.). Bureau of Labor Statistics. Retrieved December 6, 2025, from https://www.bls.gov/lau/acsqa.htm

Brooms, D. R., Clark, J. S., & Druery, J. E. (2020). "We Can Redefine Ourselves": Enhancing Black College Men's Persistence Through Counterspaces. *Journal of Black Studies*, *52*(3), 277-295. https://doi-org.proxy.library.vanderbilt.edu/10.1177/0021934720976410 (Original work published 2021)

Conwell, J. A., & Quadlin, N. (2022). Race, Gender, Higher Education, and Socioeconomic Attainment: Evidence from Baby Boomers at Midlife. *Social Forces*, *100*(3), 990–1024. https://doi.org/10.1093/sf/soab010

Hamann, K., Pilotti, M. A., & Wilson, B. M. (2021). What lies beneath: The role of self-efficacy, causal attribution habits, and gender in accounting for the success of college students. *Education Sciences*, *11*(7), 333.

LaSane, H. (2025, November 14). Black male college enrollment is falling. Here's why that matters. *U.S. News & World Report*. https://www.usnews.com/opinion/articles/2025-11-14/black-college-university-students-hbcu-opinion

McNeill, I. T., Carrasquilla, A., Asfaw, Z. K., Barthélemy, E. J., Mehr, A., Townsend, K. D., Joseph, A., Bederson, J. B., Butts, G. C., & Germano, I. M. (2023). Breaking boundaries through Doctors Reaching Minority Men Exploring Neuroscience: a mentorship model to foster a pipeline for underrepresented minorities. *Journal of Neurosurgery.*, *138*(2), 533–539. https://doi.org/10.3171/2022.5.jns22196

Witteveen, D., & Attewell, P. (2022). Black-White incentive inequality for college persistence. *Rationality and Society*, *34*(2), 155-184. https://doi-org.proxy.library.vanderbilt.edu/10.1177/10434631221091225 (Original work published 2022)

Zhou, X., & Pan, G. (2023). Higher Education and the Black-White Earnings Gap. *American Sociological Review*, *88*(1), 154-188. https://doi-org.proxy.library.vanderbilt.edu/10.1177/00031224221141887 (Original work published 2023)